

Early Origins to the 19th Century



In an age of medical specialization in which an expert in neurology will know little about the latest developments in medicine for the ear, nose, and throat, it is difficult to imagine the practices of an earlier time, when healing was holistic in nature and heavily reliant on magic, mysticism, and age-old oral traditions.

From the earliest times, medicinal plants have been crucial in sustaining the health and the well-being of mankind. Flaxseed (*Linum usitatissimum*, p. 109), for example, provided its harvesters with a nutritious food oil, fuel, a cosmetic balm for the skin, and fiber to make fabric. At the same time it was used to treat conditions such as bronchitis, respiratory congestion, boils, and a number of digestive problems. Given the life-enhancing benefits that this and so many other plants conferred, it is hardly surprising that most cultures believed them to have magical as well as medicinal abilities. It is reasonable to assume that for tens of thousands of years herbs were probably used as much for their ritual magical powers as for their medicinal qualities. A 60,000-year-old burial site excavated in Iraq, for instance, was found to

contain eight different medicinal plants, including ephedra (*Ephedra sinica*, p. 95). The inclusion of the plants in the tomb suggests they had supernatural significance as well as medicinal value.

In some cultures, plants were considered to have souls. Even Aristotle, the 4th-century BCE Greek philosopher, thought that plants had a “psyche,” albeit of a lesser order than the human soul. In Hinduism, which dates back to at least 1500 BCE, many plants are sacred to specific divinities. For example, the bael tree (*Aegle marmelos*, p. 161) is said to shelter Shiva, the god of health, beneath its branches.

In medieval Europe, the Doctrine of Signatures stated there was a connection between how a plant looked—God’s “signature”—and how it might be used medicinally. For example, the mottled leaves of lungwort (*Pulmonaria officinalis*, p. 259) were thought to resemble lung tissue, and the plant is still used to treat ailments of the respiratory tract.

Even in Western cultures, beliefs in plant spirits linger. Until the first half of the 20th century, British farm workers would not cut down elder trees (*Sambucus nigra*, p. 132) for fear of arousing the anger of the Elder Mother, the spirit who lived in and protected the tree.

In a similar vein, native peoples of the Andes in South America believe that the coca plant (*Erythroxylum coca*, p. 206) is protected by Mama Coca, a spirit who must be respected and placated if the leaves are to be harvested and used.

Shamanistic Medicine

In many traditional societies today, the world is believed to be shaped by good and evil spirits. In these societies, illness is thought to stem from malignant forces or possession by evil spirits. If a member of the tribe falls ill, the shaman (the “medicine” man or woman) is expected to intercede with the spirit world to bring about a cure. Shamans often enter the spiritual realm with the aid of hallucinogenic plants or fungi, such as ayahuasca (*Banisteriopsis caapi*, p. 176), taken by Amazonian shamans, or fly agaric (*Amanita muscaria*), taken by traditional healers of the Siberian steppes.

At the same time, the shaman provides medical treatment for the physical needs of the patient—putting salves and compresses on wounds, boiling up decoctions and barks for internal treatment, stimulating sweating for fevers, and so



Mistletoe, which the Druids called “golden bough,” had a central place in their shamanistic religious and healing ceremonies. The Druids had a well-developed knowledge of medicinal plants.